

Chapter III

The Interview



RAOUL made one step towards the girl who thus called him.

‘But my horse, madame?’ said he.

‘Oh! you are terribly embarrassed! Go yonder way—there is a shed in the outer court: fasten your horse, and return quickly!’

‘I obey, madame.’

Raoul was not four minutes in performing what he had been directed to do; he returned to the little door, where, in the gloom, he found his mysterious conductress waiting for him, on the first steps of a winding staircase.

‘Are you brave enough to follow me, monsieur knight errant?’ asked the girl, laughing at the momentary hesitation Raoul had manifested.

The latter replied by springing up the dark staircase after her. They thus climbed up three stories, he behind her, touching with his hands, when he felt for the banister, a silk dress which rubbed against each side of the staircase. At every false step made by Raoul, his conductress cried, ‘Hush!’ and held out to him a soft perfumed hand.

‘One would mount thus to the belfry of the castle without being conscious of fatigue,’ said Raoul.

‘All of which means, monsieur, that you are very much perplexed, very tired, and very uneasy. But be of good cheer, monsieur; here we are, at our destination.’

The girl threw open a door, which immediately, without any transition, filled with a flood of light the landing of the staircase, at the top of which Raoul appeared, holding fast by the balustrade.

The girl continued to walk on—he followed her; she entered a chamber—he did the same.

As soon as he was fairly in the net he heard a loud cry, and, turning round, saw at two paces from him, with her hands clasped and her eyes closed, that beautiful fair girl with blue eyes and white shoulders, who, recognizing him, called him Raoul.

He saw her, and divined at once so much love and so much joy in the expression of her countenance, the he sank on his knees in the middle of the chamber, murmuring, on his part, the name of Louise.

‘Ah! Montalais!—Montalais!’ she sighed, ‘it is very wicked to deceive me so.’

‘Who, I? I have deceived you?’

‘Yes; you told me you would go down to inquire the news, and you have brought up monsieur!’

‘Well, I was obliged to do so—how else could he have received the letter you wrote him?’ And she pointed with her finger to the letter which was still upon the table.

Raoul made a step to take it; Louise, more rapid, although she had sprung forward with a sufficiently remarkable physical hesitation, reached out her hand to stop him. Raoul came in contact with that trembling hand, took it within his own, and carried it so respectfully to his lips, that he might have been said to have deposited a sigh upon it rather than a kiss.

In the meantime, Mademoiselle de Montalais had taken the letter, folded it carefully, as women do, in three folds, and slipped it into her bosom.

‘Don’t be afraid, Louise,’ said she; ‘monsieur will no more venture to take it hence than the defunct king Louis XIII ventured to take billets from the corsage of Mademoiselle de Hautefort.’

Raoul blushed at seeing the smile of the two girls; and he did not remark that the hand of Louise remained in his.

‘There!’ said Montalais, ‘you have pardoned me, Louise, for having brought monsieur to you; and you, monsieur, bear me no malice for having followed me to see mademoiselle. Now, then, peace being made, let us chat like old friends. Present me, Louise, to M. de Bragelonne.’

‘Monsieur le Vicomte,’ said Louise, with her quiet grace and ingenious smile, ‘I have the honour to present to you Mademoiselle Aure de



A SOFT VOICE CALLED HIM FROM THE DEPTHS OF AN OBSCURE PATH

all the domestics, with a buzzing like that of several bee-hives, surrounded Raoul for the purpose of questioning him.

Madame saw this movement, and called M. de Saint-Rémy.

‘This is not the time for gossiping, but working,’ said she, with the tone of an angry housekeeper.

A. de Saint-Rémy hastened to break the circle formed by the officers round Raoul, so that the latter was able to gain the ante-chamber.

‘Care will be taken of that gentleman, I hope,’ added Madame, addressing M. de Saint-Rémy.

The worthy man immediately hastened after Raoul. ‘Madame desires refreshments to be offered to you,’ said he; ‘and there is, besides, a lodging for you in the castle.’

‘Thanks, M. de Saint-Rémy,’ replied Raoul; ‘but you know how anxious I must be to pay my duty to M. le Comte, my father.’

‘That is true, that is true, Monsieur Raoul; present him, at the same time, my humble respects, if you please.’

Raoul thus once more got rid of the old gentleman, and pursued his way. As he was passing under the porch, leading his horse by the bridle, a soft voice called him from the depths of an obscure path.

‘Monsieur Raoul!’ said the voice.

The young man turned round, surprised, and saw a dark complexioned girl, who, with a finger on her lip, held out her other hand to him. This young lady was an utter stranger.

Montalais, maid of honour to her royal highness Madame, and moreover my friend—my excellent friend.’

Raoul bowed ceremoniously.

‘And me, Louise,’ said he—‘will you not present me also to mademoiselle?’

‘Oh, she knows you—she knows all!’

This ungarded expression made Montalais laugh and Raoul sigh with happiness, for he interpreted it thus: ‘She knows all our love.’

‘The ceremonies being over, Monsieur le Vicomte,’ said Montalais, ‘take a chair, and tell us quickly the news you bring flying thus.’

‘Mademoiselle, it is no longer a secret; the king, on his way to Poitiers, will stop at Blois, to visit his royal highness.’

‘The king here!’ exclaimed Montalais, clapping her hands. ‘What! are we going to see the court? Only think, Louise—the real court from Paris!’

Oh, good heavens! But when will this happen, monsieur?’

‘Perhaps this evening, mademoiselle; at latest, to-morrow.’

Montalais lifted her shoulders in a sigh of vexation.

‘No time to get ready! No time to prepare a single dress! We are as far behind the fashions as the Poles. We shall look like portraits from the time of Henry IV. Ah, monsieur! this is sad news you bring us!’

‘But, mesdemoiselles, you will be still beautiful!’

‘That’s no news! Yes, we shall always be beautiful, because nature has made us passable; but we shall be ridiculous, because the fashion will have forgotten us. Alas! ridiculous! I shall be thought ridiculous—I!’

‘And by whom?’ said Louise, innocently.

‘By whom? You are a strange girl, my dear. Is that a question to put to me? I mean everybody; I mean the courtiers, the nobles; I mean the king.’

‘Pardon me, my good friend; but as here every one is accustomed to see us as we are—’

‘Granted; but that is about to change, and we shall be ridiculous, even for Blois; for close to us will be seen the fashions from Paris, and they will perceive that we are in the fashion of Blois! It is enough to make one despair!’

‘Console yourself, mademoiselle.’

‘Well, so let it be! After all, so much the worse for those who do not find me to their taste!’ said Montalais, philosophically.

'They would be very difficult to please,' replied Raoul, faithful to his regular system of gallantry.

'Thank you, Monsieur le Vicomte. We were saying, then, that the king is coming to Blois?'

'With all the court.'

'Mesdemoiselles de Mancini, will they be with them?'

'No, certainly not.'

'But as the king, it is said, cannot do without Mademoiselle Mary?'

'Mademoiselle, the king must do without her. M. le Cardinal will have it so. He has exiled his nieces to Brouage.'

'He!—the hypocrite!'

'Hush!' said Louise, pressing a finger on her friend's rosy lips.

'Bah! nobody can hear me. I say that old Mazarino Mazarini is a hypocrite, who burns impatiently to make his niece Queen of France.'

'That cannot be, mademoiselle, since M. le Cardinal, on the contrary, had brought about the marriage of his majesty with the Infanta Maria Theresa.'

Montalais looked Raoul full in the face, and said, 'And do you Parisians believe in these tales? Well! we are a little more knowing than you, at Blois.'

'Mademoiselle, if the king goes beyond Poitiers and sets out for Spain; if the articles of the marriage contract are agreed upon by Don Luis de Haro and his eminence, you must plainly perceive that it is not child's play.'

'All very fine! but the king is king, I suppose?'

'No doubt, mademoiselle; but the cardinal is the cardinal.'

'The king is not a man, then! And he does not love Mary Mancini?'

'He adores her.'

'Well, he will marry her then. We shall have war with Spain. M. Mazarin will spend a few of the millions he has put away; our gentlemen will perform prodigies of valour in their encounters with the proud Castilians, and many of them will return crowned with laurels, to be recrowned by us with myrtles. Now, that is my view of politics.'

'Montalais, you are wild!' said Louise, 'and every exaggeration attracts you as light does a moth.'

'Much nearer, monseigneur; his majesty must by this time have arrived at Meung.'

'Does the court accompany him?'

'Yes, monseigneur.'

'À propos, I forgot to ask you after M. le Cardinal.'

'His eminence appears to enjoy good health, monseigneur.'

'His nieces accompany him, no doubt?'

'No, monseigneur; his eminence has ordered the Mesdemoiselles de Mancini to set out for Brouage. They will follow the left bank of the Loire, while the court will come by the right.'

'What! Mademoiselle Mary de Mancini quit the court in that manner?' asked Monsieur, his reserve beginning to diminish.

'Mademoiselle Mary de Mancini in particular,' replied Raoul discreetly. A fugitive smile, an imperceptible vestige of his ancient spirit of intrigue, shot across the pale face of the prince.

'Thanks, M. de Bragelonne,' then said Monsieur. 'You would, perhaps, not be willing to carry M. le Prince the commission with which I would charge you, and that is, that his messenger has been very agreeable to me; but I will tell him so myself.'

Raoul bowed his thanks to Monsieur for the honour he had done him.

Monsieur made a sign to Madame, who struck a bell which was placed at her right hand; M. de Saint-Rémy entered, and the room was soon filled with people.

'Messieurs,' said the prince, 'his majesty is about to pay me the honour of passing a day at Blois; I depend on the king, my nephew, not having to repent of the favour he does my house.'

'Vive le Roi!' cried all the officers of the household with frantic enthusiasm, and M. de Saint-Rémy louder than the rest.

Gaston hung down his head with evident chagrin. He had all his life been obliged to hear, or rather to undergo, this cry of 'Vive le Roi!' which passed over him. For a long time, being unaccustomed to hear it, his ear had had rest, and now a younger, more vivacious, and more brilliant royalty rose up before him, like a new and more painful provocation.

Madame perfectly understood the sufferings of that timid, gloomy heart; she rose from the table, Monsieur irritated her mechanically, and

Raoul began to read, Monsieur giving again all his attention. The letter was conceived in these terms:

Monseigneur—

The king is about to set out for the frontiers. You are aware the marriage of his majesty is concluded upon. The king has done me the honour to appoint me his *maréchal-des-logis* for this journey, and as I knew with what joy his majesty would pass a day at Blois, I venture to ask your royal highness's permission to mark the house you inhabit as our quarters. If, however, the suddenness of this request should create to your royal highness any embarrassment, I entreat you to say so by the messenger I send, a gentleman of my suite, M. le Vicomte de Bragelonne. My itinerary will depend on your royal highness's determination, and instead of passing through Blois, we shall come through Vendôme or Romorantin. I venture to hope that your royal highness will be pleased with my arrangement, it being the expression of my boundless desire to make myself agreeable to you.

'Nothing can be more gracious toward us,' said Madame, who had more than once consulted the looks of her husband during the reading of the letter. 'The king here!' exclaimed she, in a rather louder tone than would have been necessary to preserve secrecy.

'Monsieur,' said his royal highness in his turn, 'you will offer my thanks to M. de Condé, and express to him my gratitude for the honour he has done me.' Raoul bowed.

'On what day will his majesty arrive?' continued the prince.

'The king, monseigneur, will in all probability arrive this evening.'

'But how, then, could he have known my reply if it had been in the negative?'

'I was desired, monseigneur, to return in all haste to Beaugency, to give counter-orders to the courier, who was himself to go back immediately with counter-orders to M. le Prince.'

'His majesty is at Orléans, then?'

'Louise, you are so extremely reasonable, that you will never know how to love.'

'Oh!' said Louise, in a tone of tender reproach, 'don't you see, Montalais? The queen-mother desires to marry her son to the Infanta: would you wish him to disobey his mother? Is it for a royal heart like his to set such a bad example? When parents forbid love, love must be banished.'

And Louise sighed: Raoul cast down his eyes, with an expression of constraint. Montalais, on her part, laughed aloud.

'Well, I have no parents!' said she.

'You are acquainted, without doubt, with the state of health of M. le Comte de la Fère?' said Louise, after breathing that sigh which had revealed so many griefs in its eloquent utterance.

'No, mademoiselle,' replied Raoul, 'I have not let paid my respects to my father; I was going to his house when Mademoiselle de Montalais so kindly stopped me. I hope the comte is well. You have heard nothing to the contrary, have you?'

'No, M. Raoul—nothing, thank God!'

Here, for several instants, ensued a silence, during which two spirits, which followed the same idea, communicated perfectly, without even the assistance of a single glance.

'Oh, heavens!' exclaimed Montalais in a fright; 'there is somebody coming up.'

'Who can it be?' said Louise, rising in great agitation.

'Mesdemoiselles, I inconvenience you very much. I have, without doubt, been very indiscreet,' stammered Raoul, very ill at ease.

'It is a heavy step,' said Louise.

'Ah! if it is only M. Malicorne,' added Montalais, 'do not disturb yourselves.'

Louise and Raoul looked at each other to inquire who M. Malicorne could be.

'There is no occasion to mind him,' continued Montalais; 'he is not jealous.'

'But, mademoiselle—' said Raoul.

'Yes, I understand. Well, he is discreet as I am.'

'Good heavens!' cried Louise, who had applied her ear to the door, which had been left ajar; 'it is my mother's step!'

'Madame de Saint-Rémy! Where shall I hide myself?' exclaimed Raoul, catching at the dress of Montalais, who looked quite bewildered.

'Yes,' said she; 'yes, I know the clicking of those pattens! It is our excellent mother. M. le Vicomte, what a pity it is the window looks upon a stone pavement, and that fifty paces below it.'

Raoul glanced at the balcony in despair. Louise seized his arm and held it tight.

'Oh, how silly I am!' said Montalais; 'have I not the robe-of-ceremony closet? It looks as if it were made on purpose.'

It was quite time to act; Madame de Saint-Rémy was coming up at a quicker pace than usual. She gained the landing at the moment when Montalais, as in all scenes of surprises, shut the closet by leaning with her back against the door.

'Ah!' cried Madame de Saint-Rémy, 'you are here, are you, Louise?'

'Yes, madame,' replied she, more pale than if she had committed a great crime.

'Well, well!'

'Pray be scared, madame,' said Montalais, offering her a chair, which she placed so that the back was towards the closet.

'Thank you, Mademoiselle Aure—thank you. Come, my child, be quick.'

'Where do you wish me to go, madame?'

'Why, home, to be sure; have you not to prepare your toilette?'

'What did you say?' cried Montalais, hastening to affect surprise, so fearful was she that Louise would in some way commit herself.

'You don't know the news, then?' said Madame de Saint-Rémy.

'What news, madame, is it possible for two girls to learn up in this dove-cote?'

'What! have you seen nobody?'

'Madame, you talk in enigmas, and you torment us at a slow fire!' cried Montalais, who, terrified at seeing Louise become paler and paler, did not know to what saint to put up her vows.

At length she caught an eloquent look of her companion's, one of those looks which would convey intelligence to a brick wall. Louise directed her attention to a hat—Raoul's unlucky hat, which was set out in all its feathery splendour upon the table.

'This minute, monseigneur.'

'How is the king?'

'His majesty is in perfect health, monseigneur.'

'And my sister-in-law?'

'Her majesty the queen-mother still suffers from the complaint in her chest, but for the last month she has been rather better.'

'Somebody told me you came on the part of M. le Prince. They must have been mistaken, surely?'

'No, monseigneur; M. le Prince has charged me to convey this letter to your royal highness, and I am to wait for an answer to it.'

Raoul had been a little annoyed by this cold and cautious reception, and his voice insensibly sank to a low key.

The prince forgot that he was the cause of this apparent mystery, and his fears returned.

He received the letter from the Prince de Condé with a haggard look, unsealed it as he would have unsealed a suspicious packet, and in order to read it so that no one should remark the effects of it upon his countenance, he turned round.

Madame followed, with an anxiety almost equal to that of the prince, every maneuver of her august husband.

Raoul, impassible, and a little disengaged by the attention of his hosts, looked from his place through the open window at the gardens and the statues which peopled them.

'Well!' cried Monsieur, all at once, with a cheerful smile; 'there is an agreeable surprise, and a charming letter from M. le Prince. Look, Madame!'

The table was too large to allow the arm of the prince to reach the hand of Madame; Raoul sprang forward to be their intermediary, and did it with so good a grace as to procure a flattering acknowledgement from the princess.

'You know the contents of this letter, no doubt?' said Gaston to Raoul. 'Yes, monseigneur; M. le Prince at first gave me the message verbally, but upon reflection his highness took up his pen.'

'It is beautiful writing,' said Madame, 'but I cannot read it.'

'Will you read it to Madame, M. de Bragelonne?' said the duke.

'Yes, read it, if you please, monsieur.'

'A messenger from M. le Prince!' said Gaston, with an inquietude that escaped none of the assistants, and consequently redoubled the general curiosity.

Monsieur, perhaps, fancied himself brought back again to the happy times when the opening of a door gave him an emotion, in which every letter might contain a state secret,—in which every message was connected with a dark and complicated intrigue. Perhaps, likewise, that great name of M. le Prince expanded itself, beneath the roofs of Blois, to the proportions of a phantom.

Monsieur pushed away his plate.

'Shall I tell the envoy to wait?' asked M. de Saint-Rémy.

A glance from Madame emboldened Gaston, who replied: 'No, no! let him come in at once, on the contrary. À propos, who is he?'

'A gentleman of this country, M. le Vicomte de Bragelonne.'

'Ah, very well! Introduce him, Saint-Rémy—introduce him.'

And when he had let fall these words, with his accustomed gravity, Monsieur turned his eyes, in a certain manner, upon the people of his suite, so that all, pages, officers, and equestries, quitted the service, knives and goblets, and made towards the second chamber door a retreat as rapid as it was disorderly.

This little army had dispersed in two files when Raoul de Bragelonne, preceded by M. de Saint-Rémy, entered the refectory.

The short interval of solitude which this retreat had left him, permitted Monsieur the time to assume a diplomatic countenance. He did not turn round, but waited till the maître d'hôtel should bring the messenger face to face with him.

Raoul stopped even with the lower end of the table, so as to be exactly between Monsieur and Madame. From this place he made a profound bow to Monsieur, and a very humble one to Madame; then, drawing himself up into military pose, he waited for Monsieur to address him.

On his part the prince waited till the doors were hermetically closed; he would not turn round to ascertain the fact, as that would have been derogatory to his dignity, but he listened with all his ears for the noise of the lock, which would promise him at least an appearance of secrecy.

The doors being closed, Monsieur raised his eyes towards the vicomte, and said, 'It appears that you come from Paris, monsieur?'

Montalais sprang towards it, and, seizing it with her left hand, passed it behind her into the right, concealing it as she was speaking.

'Well,' said Madame de Saint-Rémy, 'a courier has arrived, announcing the approach of the king. There, mesdemoiselles; there is something to make you put on your best looks.'

'Quick, quick!' cried Montalais. 'Follow Madame your mother, Louise; and leave me to get ready my dress of ceremony.'

Louise arose; her mother took her by the hand, and led her out on to the landing.

'Come along,' said she; then adding in a low voice, 'When I forbid you to come the apartment of Montalais, why do you do so?'

'Madame, she is my friend. Besides, I had but just come.'

'Did you see nobody concealed while you were there?'

'Madame!'

'I saw a man's hat, I tell you—the hat of that fellow, that good-for-nothing!'

'Madame!' repeated Louise.

'Of that do-nothing Malicorne! A maid of honour to have such company—fie! fie!' and their voices were lost in the depths of the narrow staircase.

Montalais had not missed a word of this conversation, which echo conveyed to her as if through a tunnel. She shrugged her shoulders on seeing Raoul, who had listened likewise, issue from the closet.

'Poor Montalais!' said she, 'the victim of friendship! Poor Malicorne, the victim of love!'

She stopped on viewing the tragic-comic face of Raoul, who was vexed at having, in one day, surprised so many secrets.

'Oh, mademoiselle!' said he; 'how can we repay your kindness?'

'Oh, we will balance accounts some day,' said she. 'For the present, begone, M. de Bragelonne, for Madame de Saint-Rémy is not over indulgent; and any indiscretion on her part might bring hither a domiciliary visit, which would be disagreeable to all parties.'

'But Louise—how shall I know—'

'Begone! begone! King Louis XI knew very well what he was about when he invented the post.'

'Alas!' sighed Raoul.

‘And am I not here—I, who am worth all the posts in the kingdom? Quick, I say, to horse! so that if Madame de Saint-Rémy should return for the purpose of preaching me a lesson on morality, she may not find you here.’

‘She would tell my father, would she not?’ murmured Raoul.

‘And you would be scolded. Ah, vicomte, it is very plain you come from court; you are as timid as the king. *Peste!* at Blois we contrive better than that, to do without papa’s consent. Ask Malicorne else!’

And at these words the girl pushed Raoul out of the room by the shoulders. He glided swiftly down to the porch, regained his horse, mounted, and set off as if he had had Monsieur’s guards at his heels.

As soon as he had disappeared in the interior of the palace, the window of the court was repeople, and an animated whispering betrayed the emotion of the two girls. They soon appeared to have formed a resolution, for one of the two faces disappeared from the window. This was the brunette; the other remained behind the balcony, concealed by the flowers, watching attentively through the branches the perron by which M. de Bragelonne had entered the castle.

In the meantime the object of so much laudable curiosity continued his route, following the steps of the maître d’hôtel. The noise of quick steps, an odour of wine and viands, a clinking of crystal and plates, warned them that they were coming to the end of their course.

The pages, valets and officers, assembled in the office which led up to the refectory, welcomed the newcomer with the proverbial politeness of the country; some of them were acquainted with Raoul, and all knew that he came from Paris. It might be said that his arrival for a moment suspended the service. In fact, a page, who was pouring out wine for his royal highness, on hearing the jingling of spurs in the next chamber, turned round like a child, without perceiving that he was continuing to pour out, not into the glass, but upon the tablecloth.

Madame, who was not so preoccupied as her glorious spouse was, remarked this distraction of the page.

‘Well?’ exclaimed she.

‘Well!’ repeated Monsieur; ‘what is going on then?’

A. de Saint-Rémy, who had just introduced his head through the doorway, took advantage of the moment.

‘Why am I to be disturbed?’ said Gaston, helping himself to a thick slice of one of the largest salmon that had ever ascended the Loire to be captured between Paimboeuf and Saint-Nazaire.

‘There is a messenger from Paris. Oh! but after monseigneur has breakfasted will do; there is plenty of time.’

‘From Paris!’ cried the prince, letting his fork fall. ‘A messenger from Paris, do you say? And on whose part does this messenger come?’

‘On the part of M. le Prince,’ said the maître d’hôtel promptly. Every one knows that the Prince de Condé was so called.